Lesson 33 material: Grammar: Embedded Questions

English Stage 2 (B2) · Unit 3: Verb Tenses and Narration · The Human Lifespan

9.4: Grammar Presentation-Embedded Questions

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Changes: formatted for print; exercise answers are in the study guide.

Embedded questions are noun clauses, which are dependent clauses. Embedded questions use statement word order as opposed to question word order. They can function as the subject, direct or indirect object, or an adjective complement.

Question: Where is my shoe?

Subject: Where my shoe is will eventually be determined.

Object: I don't know where my shoe is.

Object of a preposition: I would like you to focus on where my shoe is.

Adjective complement: It is unclear where my shoe is.

For more information on this topic, watch these videos: Noun Clauses with Wh-Words and Noun Clauses with if or whether

Video: https://youtu.be/1BEkdVMJZao

Video: https://youtu.be/zPoUhWvhHU8

This chapter's reading had several embedded questions. As you read the sentences from this chapter's reading, think about the function of each embedded question. Is it a subject? object? Check your answers in the Answer Key.

1. Unfortunately, no matter **how you feel**, you cannot choose **when you will start to experience changes** or **what will happen**. (Paragraph 1)
2. You begin to think more often about abstract ideas, such as love and beauty, rather than thinking just about **what you can see and feel**. (Paragraph 4)
3. If I asked you when you were seven years old **what your favorite song was**, you might respond with a song from the 80s or 90s. (Paragraph 5)
4. This is **what people usually refer to** when talking about "puberty." (Paragraph 6)
5. These are just a few examples of **how much your body changes during this time period**. (Paragraph 7)
6. **Why you feel these things** can seem like a mystery. (Paragraph 8)
7. In fact, it's always good to talk about **what you're going through**. (Paragraph 10)
8. You might feel like you don't recognize yourself and have no control over **what's happening**. (Paragraph 10)
9. The more people talk about these things, the more everyone will realize **how normal it is**. (Paragraph 10)

3.2.4.1. Patterns and Examples

Question: Question word + auxiliary + subject + verb?

What does she study?

Embedded Question-[Subject]: [Question word + subject + verb] + verb.

What she studies is difficult.

Embedded Question-[Object]: Subject + verb + [question word + subject + verb].

I wonder what she studies.

Embedded Question-[Adjective Complement]: It + be verb + adjective + [question word + subject + verb].

It was obvious what she studies.

3.2.4.2. Note on Dependent Clauses

There are three types of dependent clauses: noun, adjective, and adverb. All three types might use the same word as a relative pronoun or subordinating conjunction.

Noun Clause: **When they will arrive** is unknown.

Adjective Clause: The day **when they arrived** was hectic.

Adverb Clause: **When they arrive**, we will begin.

Notice how all of the dependent clauses begin with “when”. Another common word used by noun and adjective clauses is “that”. Being able to distinguish the difference between adjective and noun clauses can be useful for reading comprehension. Also, understanding the differences between the dependent clauses will help you in word order and punctuation when writing.

3.2.4.3. Exercise 3-Sentence Completion

Complete the sentences with the appropriate form of an embedded question.

1. I can’t remember _____.
a. which book did he want you to buy
b. which book he wanted you to buy
2. They didn’t tell me _____.
a. why aren’t your friends at home studying
b. why didn’t your friends at home studying
c. why your friends aren’t at home studying
3. Did he tell you _____?
a. what did he find
b. what he found
c. what he finds
4. I know _____.
a. how many states are there
b. how many states there are
5. Guess _____!
a. what did I buy
b. what I buy
c. what I bought
6. It’s none of your business _____.
a. how old am I
b. how old I am
7. They were warned about _____.
a. which neighbors should I avoid
b. which neighbors I should avoid
8. The children are excited about _____.
a. where they will go trick-or-treating
b. where will they go trick-or-treating
9. My friend will be mad at his brother for _____.
a. what did he say to their mother
b. what he says to their mother
c. what he said to their mother
10. I will ask her _____.
a. where is the best sushi restaurant
b. where the best sushi restaurant is
11. _____ depends on your preparation.
a. How long it will take
b. How long will it take
12. _____ seems obvious.
a. How he can fix his relationship
b. How can he fix his relationship
13. _____ is eleven days earlier every year.
a. When do we celebrate Eid

b. When we celebrate Eid

14. Do you know _____?

a. what we will have for dinner

b. what will we have for dinner

15. Can you tell me _____?

a. where is the nearest restroom

b. where the nearest restroom is

16. I don't care _____.

a. which topic he chooses

b. which topic does he choose

c. which topic does he chooses

3.2.4.4. Exercise 4-Objects of Prepositions

Use the questions to create statements with embedded questions as object of prepositions. Use the example to guide you.

Example: Question-What languages does she speak at home?

Answer-I am interested in what languages she speaks at home.

1. Question: Where will I see him?

Answer: I think about

2. Question: Who is your teacher?

Answer: I was surprised about

3. Question: Whose car was he driving?

Answer: I am unaware of

4. Question: Why are they smiling?

Answer: I am interested in

5. Question: Where are you in your career?

Answer: I am proud of

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3.2.4.5. Exercise 5-Editing Embedded Questions

Identify and correct embedded question errors in the paragraph about age ceremonies across cultures.

All children around the world eventually become adolescents; however, when is their coming of age celebrated depends on their culture. In the Jewish faith, 12 to 13-year-old boys and girls participate in a celebration called a Bar and Bat Mitzvah. Jewish historians offer many theories on how did this celebration began, but it rose in importance during the 18th and 19th centuries. In the Christian faith, 14-year-old boys and girls participate in the ritual of confirmation. Confirmation is what does signals the adolescent is a full member of society. A girl's 15th birthday is when do many Latin American cultures celebrate a girl's passage to womanhood. However, various Latin American cultures differ in how do they celebrate the Quinceañera. Finally, the United States celebrates boys and girls at 16 years old ("sweet sixteen"). Why are adolescents celebrated at 16 in America is unknown, but some speculate that 16 gives adolescents freedom since they are allowed to get their driver's license. Becoming an adult means having the freedom to choose what do you want to do with life. However, these ceremonies mean taking new responsibilities. What do these ceremonies demonstrate is that becoming an adult is an entire community of friends, family, and neighbors.

"Editing Embedded Questions" is derived from "Coming of Age Ceremonies Across Different Cultures" by Thomas Pool licensed by CommonLit under CC BY-NC-SA.

Links on the original page

- Noun Clauses with Wh-Words: https://youtu.be/1BEkdVMJZao
- Noun Clauses with if or whether: https://youtu.be/zPoUhWvhHU8
- ESL for High-Intermediate Students: The Way You Like It: https://docs.google.com/document/d/1E09eioDQntcobV9CpeXvg58UitGc_cGjk5f5bcvoIlA/edit
- Coming of Age Ceremonies Across Different Cultures: https://www.commonlit.org/en/texts/coming-of-age-ceremonies-across-different-cultures

9.5: Communication Practice

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3.2.5.1. Exercise 6-What Do You Know?

Complete the sentences and compare with a partner.

1. I don't know
2. I want to know
3. Do you know
4. I wonder
5. Can you tell me

3.2.5.2. Exercise 7-I'm Not Sure…

Ask your classmate questions they may not know the answer to. Respond to your classmates' questions using embedded questions. Use the example to guide you.

Examples:

1. What is the capital of Alaska?

Answer: I'm not sure what the capital of Alaska is. Maybe Fairbanks? Oh! It's Juneau!

2. What is [classmate's name]'s favorite drink?

Answer: I don't know what [classmate's name]'s favorite drink it, but I'll ask!

Questions to ask your partner/group members:

1.

2.

3.

4.

5.